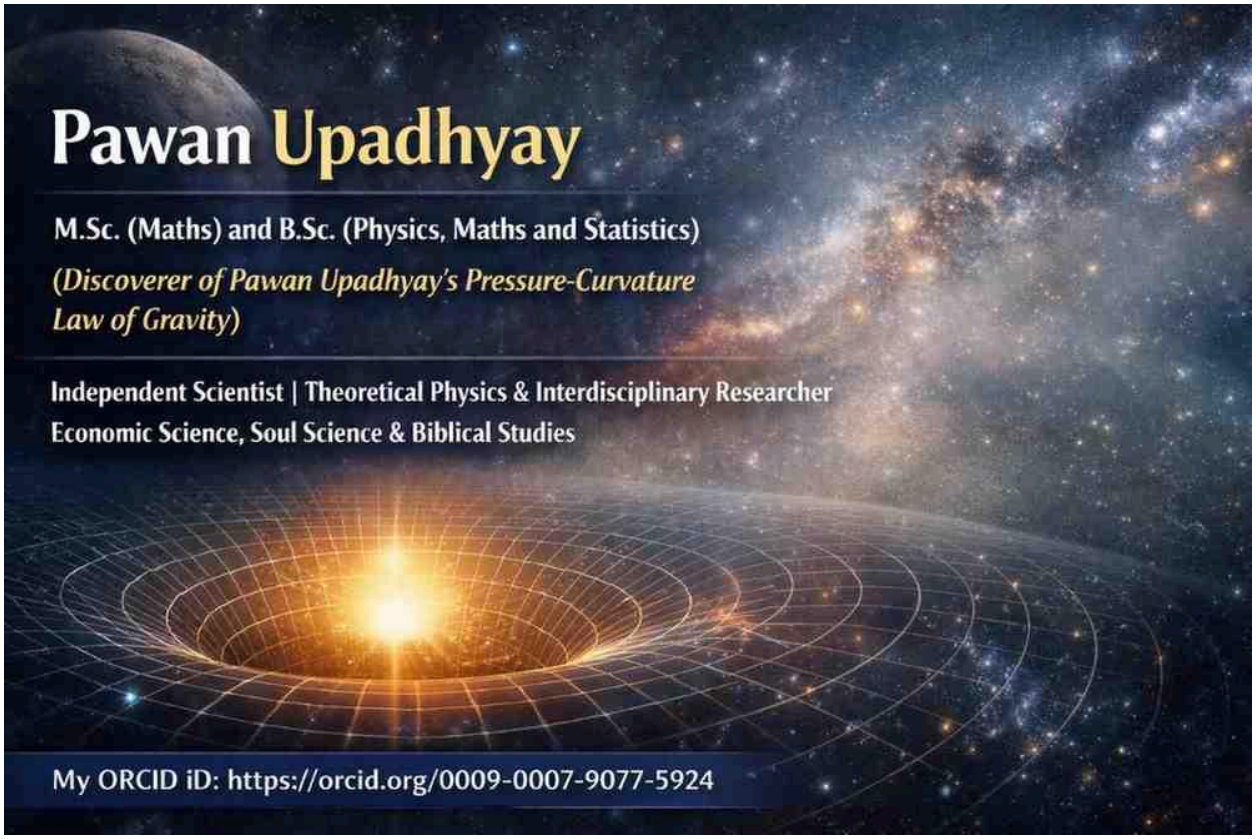
The English Word “Wise” in Greek

A Lexical and Semantic Word Study

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Abstract

The English adjective **“wise”** corresponds to several Greek expressions, but the principal classical Greek adjective is **σοφός (*sophos*)**. Its semantic range is broader than a single English equivalent. Depending on context, σοφός may mean **wise, skilled, clever, accomplished, learned, prudent, or practically intelligent**. The related noun **σοφία (*sophia*)** denotes qualities or capacities such as skill, cleverness, practical intelligence, and wisdom.

This study examines the Greek vocabulary behind the English concept “wise,” with particular attention to **σοφός** and **σοφία**. It distinguishes wisdom from mere possession of information and from mere cleverness. The study also considers how the meaning of σοφός developed from the idea of skill or competence toward broader intellectual, practical, and philosophical wisdom.

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1. Introduction

The English word **“wise”** appears simple, but its Greek equivalents have a considerably wider semantic range. A Greek speaker could use **σοφός (*sophos*)** to describe someone who was skilled in a craft, clever in practical affairs, prudent in judgment, learned, or intellectually wise.

Therefore, translating every occurrence of σοφός simply as “wise” can conceal important aspects of its meaning.

The purpose of this study is to answer a focused question:

What does the Greek word σοφός mean when English translations use the word “wise”?

The investigation will distinguish:

1. **σοφός — wise, skilled, clever, prudent**
2. **σοφία — skill, cleverness, practical wisdom, wisdom**
3. The relationship between **knowledge, skill, judgment, and wisdom**
4. The importance of context in determining the appropriate English translation.

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2. The Principal Greek Word: σοφός

Greek

σοφός

Transliteration

sophos

Part of speech

Adjective:

σοφός, σοφή, σοφόν

The basic lexical range of σοφός includes:

- wise
- skilled
- clever
- accomplished
- prudent
- learned
- knowledgeable in a particular field

The major Greek lexicon LSJ gives the short definition **“wise, skilled, clever.”** Its examples show that the word can describe people who possess practical skill, artistic ability, prudence, worldly intelligence, or intellectual learning.

This is important because **σοφός does not begin with the narrow modern English meaning of “intellectually wise.”**

Its semantic field is broader.

---

3. The Earlier Sense: Skill and Ability

One of the important senses of σοφός is **skillful or accomplished in a particular activity**.

For example, a person could be called σοφός because that person possessed exceptional ability in:

- craftsmanship
- music
- poetry
- navigation
- prophecy
- other specialized arts or activities

LSJ specifically records σοφός in contexts involving craftsmen, musicians, poets, navigators, and other skilled persons.

This gives us an important conceptual foundation:

σοφός can describe someone who knows how to do something well.

Thus, “wise” in Greek can overlap with the idea of **competence**.

A person may possess knowledge, but σοφός can emphasize the person's demonstrated ability to use that knowledge or skill effectively.

---

4. σοφός as “Clever”

Another important meaning is **clever**.

LSJ includes senses such as:

clever in practical matters

and connects this sense with **wisdom, prudence, shrewdness, and practical intelligence**.

Therefore:

σοφός ≠ merely intelligent

and

σοφός ≠ merely knowledgeable.

Rather, depending on context, σοφός can describe someone who possesses the ability to **understand circumstances and act effectively within them**.

This is why “clever” can sometimes be an appropriate translation.

However, modern English “clever” can sometimes imply trickery or manipulation. That implication should **not automatically be imported into σοφός**.

The context determines whether the word means:

- skillful,
- clever,
- prudent,
- wise,
- learned,
- or some related sense.

---

5. σοφός as “Prudent”

Another important semantic dimension is **prudence**.

Prudence concerns the ability to judge circumstances correctly and act appropriately.

Thus, the concept can be represented as:

Knowledge → Understanding → Judgment → Appropriate Action

In contexts where σοφός describes practical wisdom, the emphasis is not simply on how much someone knows but on **how that person understands and applies what is known**.

This explains why Greek discussions of σοφός can overlap with concepts such as practical judgment and intelligence.

---

6. σοφός as “Learned”

σοφός can also refer to a person who is **learned or intellectually knowledgeable**.

LSJ records a sense of σοφός meaning “learned, wise,” including philosophical contexts in which wisdom is associated with knowledge and understanding.

This produces an important distinction:

A person can be called σοφός because of learning, but the concept of σοφός is not exhausted by learning.

In other words:

Learning can contribute to σοφία, but learning alone does not necessarily constitute wisdom.

---

7. The Related Noun: σοφία

The corresponding noun is:

σοφία

Transliteration: *sophia*

The English words **wisdom** and **sophia** are closely related conceptually and linguistically.

However, σοφία has a broad semantic range.

LSJ gives senses including:

- skill
- cleverness
- practical intelligence
- practical wisdom
- learning
- wisdom
- speculative wisdom

It can therefore describe both **skill in a particular discipline** and **broader wisdom or intellectual understanding**.

This is significant for understanding σοφός.

Relationship:

σοφία → wisdom / skill / intelligence

σοφός → wise / skilled / clever / learned person

---

8. From Skill to Wisdom

The semantic development can be represented conceptually:

Skill → Competence → Practical Intelligence → Good Judgment → Wisdom

This should not be understood as a rigid historical formula in which every use of σοφός necessarily passes through these stages.

Rather, it illustrates the **semantic relationship among the different senses** recorded for the word.

The underlying concept is the possession of an ability that enables a person to understand, accomplish, or judge something well.

Thus, a skilled craftsman can be σοφός in one context, while a philosopher or learned person can be σοφός in another.

---

9. “Wise” Is Broader Than “Knowledgeable”

An important distinction is:

Knowledge

Knowledge concerns **what a person knows**.

Skill

Skill concerns **what a person knows how to do**.

Cleverness

Cleverness concerns **the ability to understand or solve something effectively**.

Wisdom

Wisdom concerns **sound understanding and judgment**.

These concepts can overlap, but they are not identical.

Therefore:

σοφός should not be reduced to the possession of information.

The word can describe a person whose knowledge is accompanied by competence, intelligence, judgment, or wisdom.

---

10. σοφός and the Idea of “Knowing How”

One useful way to understand the semantic field is through the distinction:

Knowing something

versus

knowing how to use or accomplish something.

The latter comes closer to several uses of σοφός.

For example:

A person may know the principles of music.

A skilled musician knows how to apply them.

A person may know facts about navigation.

A skilled navigator knows how to use that knowledge in practice.

Thus:

σοφός can describe the person whose knowledge has become effective ability.

This explains why the word can legitimately be translated “skilled,” “clever,” or “wise” depending upon context.

---

11. The Opposite: ἄσοφος

Greek can form the opposite of σοφός with the negative prefix **ἀ-**.

ἄσοφος

Meaning:

unwise / lacking wisdom

The formation illustrates that σοφός represents a state or quality of possessing wisdom, skill, or related competence, while ἄσοφος expresses its absence. The LSJ material explicitly notes the contrast of **σοφός — wise** and **ἄσοφος — unwise**.

---

12. The Semantic Range of σοφός

The word can therefore be organized approximately as follows:

Greek sense	Possible English rendering
Skill in an art or craft	skilled
Ability in practical affairs	clever
Sound practical judgment	prudent
Intellectual ability	intelligent
Learning	learned
Mature judgment	wise
Broad intellectual wisdom	wise
Exceptional understanding	profoundly wise

This table is **not a list of synonyms**. The appropriate translation depends upon context.

---

13. “Wise” Versus “Clever”

A particularly important distinction is between **wise** and **clever**.

They overlap, but they are not identical.

Clever

Emphasizes:

- ability
- quick understanding
- ingenuity
- practical effectiveness
- skill in solving problems

Wise

Emphasizes:

- sound judgment
- understanding
- discernment

- prudent action
- mature evaluation

Thus:

Cleverness concerns ability; wisdom concerns judgment.

A person may be clever without being wise.

Likewise, a person may be wise without displaying extraordinary cleverness.

The Greek word σοφός can cover both areas depending on context.

---

14. “Wise” Versus “Learned”

A second distinction is between **learned** and **wise**.

A learned person possesses substantial knowledge.

A wise person possesses understanding and judgment.

Therefore:

Learning → accumulation or acquisition of knowledge

Wisdom → intelligent and sound understanding of what is known

The Greek semantic field allows σοφός to describe both learned persons and genuinely wise persons.

Consequently, context must determine which aspect is primary.

---

15. “Wise” Versus “Skillful”

A third distinction is between wisdom and technical skill.

A craftsman may be σοφός because of exceptional skill.

That does not necessarily mean that the person possesses philosophical or moral wisdom.

This demonstrates why lexical interpretation must resist the temptation to give a word one universal meaning.

The safest principle is:

The lexical range provides possibilities; the context determines which possibility is active.

---

16. The Conceptual Relationship

The relationship can be represented as:

Knowledge
↓
Understanding
↓
Skill / Ability
↓
Judgment
↓
Wisdom

This is a **conceptual model**, not a dictionary definition of σοφός.

It helps explain why the Greek semantic field can connect knowledge, skill, cleverness, prudence, and wisdom without making them identical.

---

17. σοφός in Philosophical Context

Greek philosophical literature significantly expands the meaning of wisdom.

LSJ records philosophical uses in which σοφός can mean **learned, wise, or ideally wise**, and even associates the ideal wise person with possession of knowledge of what is true.

This illustrates an important development:

The word can move from **skill in a particular domain** toward **comprehensive intellectual wisdom**.

Thus the same Greek adjective can operate at different conceptual levels.

---

18. σοφία and Practical Wisdom

The noun σοφία is equally broad.

LSJ records σοφία for:

- skill in crafts,
- skill in music,
- skill in poetry,
- skill in medicine,
- practical intelligence,
- practical wisdom,
- learning,
- philosophical wisdom.

Therefore, the English translation **“wisdom”** represents only one major part of the semantic range.

In some contexts, **skill** or **cleverness** may better express the intended meaning.

---

19. Theological Caution

When σοφός appears in a Christian theological context, it should not automatically be given the entire philosophical meaning of “ultimate wisdom.”

The interpreter should first ask:

1. What is the immediate context?
2. Is the person being described as skilled?
3. Is practical intelligence emphasized?
4. Is learning emphasized?
5. Is moral judgment emphasized?
6. Is philosophical or divine wisdom intended?
7. What does the surrounding passage indicate?

Only after these questions are answered should the translator select “wise,” “clever,” “skilled,” “learned,” or another English equivalent.

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20. Summary of the Word Study

The Greek adjective:

σοφός (*sophos*)

has a broad semantic range.

Its principal meanings include:

skilled → clever → prudent → learned → wise

The related noun:

σοφία (*sophia*)

can refer to:

skill → cleverness → practical intelligence → learning → wisdom

These meanings are related but should not be treated as interchangeable in every context.

The central lexical observation is therefore:

σοφός describes a person possessing σοφία—whether that wisdom is expressed as skill, practical intelligence, prudence, learning, or broader wisdom according to context.

---

21. Conclusion

The English word **"wise"** does not correspond to a single narrow concept in Greek. The principal Greek adjective **σοφός** possesses a rich semantic range extending from **skill and cleverness to prudence, learning, and wisdom**.

Its related noun **σοφία** similarly extends from technical skill and practical intelligence to philosophical and broader wisdom.

Consequently, the Greek concept should not be reduced to the modern English idea that a wise person is simply someone who knows many things.

A more complete conceptual picture is:

Knowledge provides information.
Skill provides ability.
Cleverness provides effective problem-solving.
Prudence provides sound practical judgment.
Wisdom brings understanding and judgment together.

Thus, **σοφός** can describe someone who is not merely informed, but someone whose knowledge, ability, understanding, or judgment has reached a level that can appropriately be described as **wise**.

Primary Lexical Reference

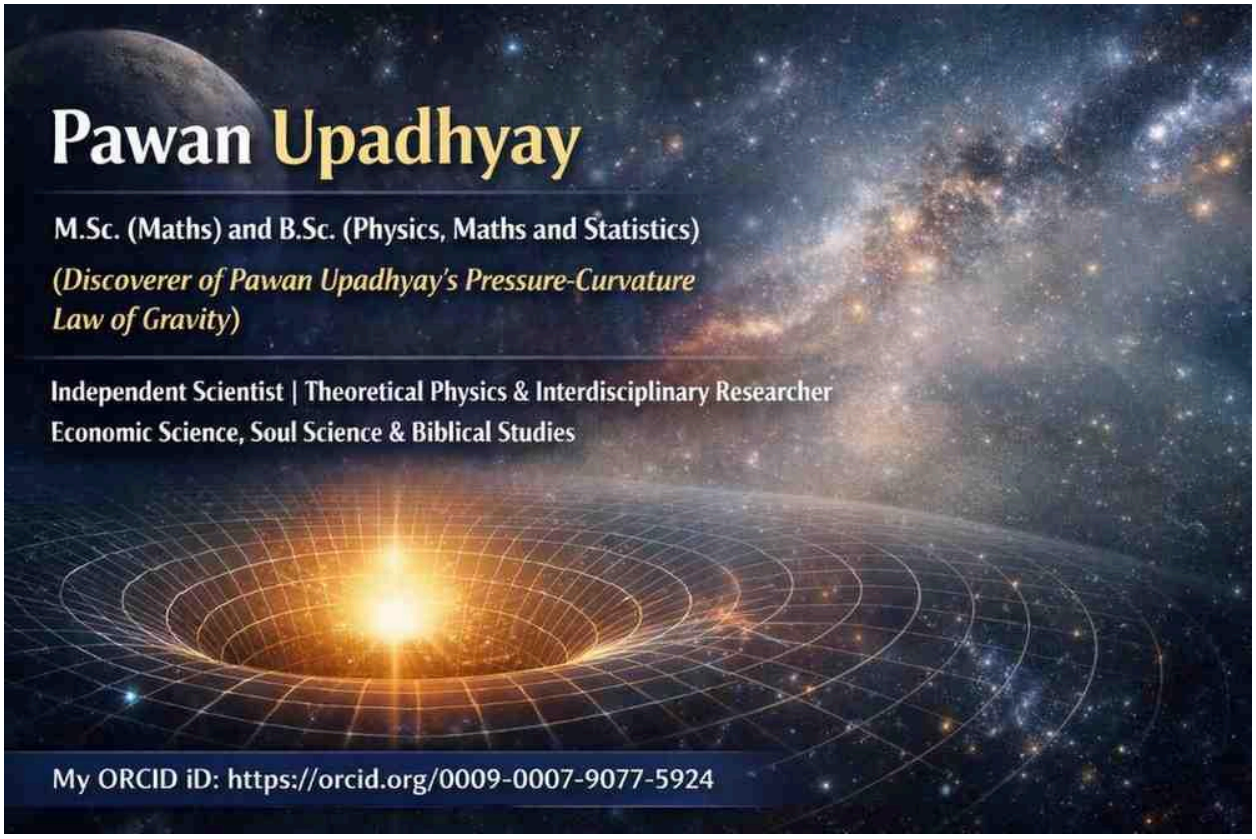
The LSJ entry for **σοφός** records the principal senses “wise, skilled, clever” and provides examples ranging from practical skill to intellectual and philosophical wisdom. The related LSJ entry for **σοφία** documents the corresponding range from skill and cleverness to practical and philosophical wisdom.

[Expanded Research Paper]

From Knowledge to Wisdom to Truth

A Greek Word Study of σοφός, σοφία, γνῶσις, and ἀλήθεια in Relation to Divine Illumination and Gospel of Thomas Saying 2

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Abstract

This study examines the relationship among four important Greek concepts—**γνῶσις (*gnōsis*, knowledge), σοφία (*sophia*, wisdom), σοφός (*sophos*, wise/skilled), and ἀλήθεια (*alētheia*, truth)**—and places them within a proposed Christian theological model of divine illumination. The study then brings this conceptual framework into dialogue with **Gospel of Thomas Saying 2**, whose Greek witness presents a progression from seeking to finding, astonishment, reigning, and resting, while the Coptic witness adds an intervening state of trouble and explicitly describes ruling "over the All."

The central argument is that the Greek vocabulary permits a meaningful conceptual distinction between **knowing**, **becoming wise**, and **recognizing truth**. γνῶσις concerns knowledge or knowing; σοφία encompasses wisdom, skill, practical intelligence, and sound judgment; σοφός describes the person characterized by such qualities; and ἀλήθεια denotes truth or what is true and real. These lexical meanings should not be collapsed into one another.

Within the theological framework proposed by this study, divine illumination enables the human person to receive knowledge; knowledge, rightly understood and integrated, develops into wisdom; wisdom enables discernment and recognition of Truth; and Truth, understood christologically within Christian theology, becomes the governing reality of the transformed person. Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 can then be read as a conceptual portrait of transformative

seeking: the seeker does not merely acquire information but undergoes a process in which finding produces astonishment, transformation produces authority, and the final movement is toward rest.

This interpretation is explicitly distinguished from a claim about the literal lexical meaning of Saying 2. The words γνῶσις, σοφία, σοφός, and ἀλήθεια do not constitute the vocabulary of the saying itself. Rather, they provide a theological vocabulary through which the transformative process described in Saying 2 may be examined.

---

1. Introduction

The search for wisdom is one of the most persistent themes in ancient religious and philosophical literature. Greek vocabulary provides several distinct but overlapping concepts for discussing knowledge, wisdom, understanding, and truth.

Among the most important are:

γνῶσις — knowledge

σοφία — wisdom

σοφός — wise / skilled / clever

ἀλήθεια — truth

These terms are related, but they are not synonyms.

A person may possess knowledge without possessing wisdom. A person may be clever without being wise. Wisdom may involve practical judgment rather than simply accumulated information. Truth concerns what is true or real and therefore cannot simply be equated with knowledge or wisdom.

This distinction becomes particularly significant when these concepts are placed beside the spiritual progression found in **Gospel of Thomas Saying 2**.

The saying begins with the command to continue seeking:

“Let the one seeking not stop seeking until he finds.”

The Greek fragment then proceeds through a remarkable sequence:

seeking → finding → astonishment → reigning → resting

The Coptic version expands the sequence:

seeking → finding → trouble → astonishment → ruling over the All

The Greek fragment of P.Oxy. 654 is especially important because it preserves the progression toward “rest,” while the Coptic version preserved at Nag Hammadi contains the additional “troubled” stage and “over the All.”

This paper asks whether the conceptual movement from **knowledge to wisdom to Truth** can provide a coherent Christian theological framework for understanding this process.

The answer proposed here is affirmative, but with an important qualification:

This is a theological synthesis, not a claim that Saying 2 itself contains these four Greek terms.

---

2. Methodological Principle

The study follows three levels of analysis.

Level 1 — Lexical Text

First, establish what the Greek words actually mean.

Level 2 — Conceptual Interpretation

Second, determine how those meanings can be related conceptually.

Level 3 — Theological Synthesis

Third, ask how these concepts may function within a Christian theological framework.

This distinction prevents a theological interpretation from being presented as though it were simply the dictionary definition of a Greek word.

The basic methodological rule is:

First establish the vocabulary; then establish the conceptual relationship; then construct the theological interpretation.

---

3. γνῶσις — Knowledge

3.1 Greek Form

γνῶσις

Transliteration:

gnōsis

Gender:

feminine

Basic meaning:

knowledge, knowing, inquiry, investigation

LSJ records γνῶσις both in the sense of inquiry or investigation and, more broadly, as **knowing or knowledge**. It can stand in opposition to ignorance and can describe knowledge in a general sense.

Thus γνῶσις begins with the concept of **coming to know**.

3.2 γνῶσις and the Process of Knowing

The word should not be reduced to the idea of possessing information.

Its semantic field is connected with the process and result of knowing.

Conceptually:

not knowing → seeking → knowing

This makes γνῶσις especially relevant to a study of seeking.

The seeker begins with something not yet fully known.

The process of seeking produces discovery.

Discovery produces knowledge.

Therefore:

Seeking → Finding → Knowing

This conceptual progression is compatible with, though not lexically identical to, the opening movement of Saying 2.

---

4. σοφία — Wisdom

4.1 Greek Form

σοφία

Transliteration:

sophia

Basic semantic range:

- skill
- cleverness
- practical intelligence
- sound judgment
- learning
- wisdom
- philosophical wisdom

The LSJ entry for σοφία begins with the meaning **skill** and records uses involving crafts, music, poetry, medicine, practical affairs, and intellectual wisdom. It also records the sense of practical wisdom and later philosophical wisdom.

This broad semantic range is essential.

---

5. Wisdom Is More Than Knowledge

A distinction can therefore be made:

γνῶσις = knowledge

σοφία = wisdom

Knowledge concerns what is known.

Wisdom concerns the intelligent and appropriate understanding and use of what is known.

A person may know many things and nevertheless lack wisdom.

Conversely, wisdom presupposes some form of understanding and knowledge but is not reducible to information.

A conceptual model can therefore be expressed:

Knowledge → Understanding → Judgment → Wisdom

This is not a dictionary definition of σοφία. It is a theological-philosophical model constructed from the broader semantic relationship of knowledge and wisdom.

---

6. σοφός — The Wise Person

6.1 Greek Form

σοφός

Transliteration:

sophos

σοφός is the adjective associated with σοφία.

Its semantic range includes:

- wise
- skilled
- clever
- accomplished
- learned
- prudent

The important point is that σοφός can describe both **technical competence** and **broader wisdom**.

A craftsman may be σοφός because he is highly skilled.

A philosopher may be σοφός because of intellectual wisdom.

A practical person may be σοφός because of sound judgment.

Thus:

σοφός describes a person characterized by σοφία in the relevant sense.

---

7. Cleverness and Wisdom

The relationship between “clever” and “wise” deserves particular attention.

Cleverness can involve:

- quick understanding
- ingenuity
- problem-solving
- practical ability
- intellectual skill

Wisdom can involve:

- discernment
- judgment
- understanding
- prudence
- appropriate action

Therefore:

Cleverness is ability; wisdom is mature judgment.

The Greek word σοφός can cover both dimensions depending upon context.

This prevents an important mistake: translating σοφός as “clever” and then importing the modern English implication of manipulation or cunning into every occurrence.

The Greek word is broader.

---

8. ἀλήθεια — Truth

8.1 Greek Form

ἀλήθεια

Transliteration:

alētheia

Basic meaning:

truth

The related adjective **ἀληθής** means **true, real, unconcealed**, and can stand in opposition to what is false or merely apparent. LSJ gives the semantic range “unconcealed, true, real,” including the contrast with falsehood and appearance.

Thus ἀλήθεια concerns the reality or truth of something.

---

9. Truth Is Not Identical with Knowledge

This distinction is fundamental.

A person can possess knowledge about something without fully understanding whether that knowledge is true.

Therefore:

Knowledge ≠ Truth

Knowledge is the human possession or recognition of something known.

Truth concerns the reality or truthfulness of that thing.

Likewise:

Wisdom ≠ Truth

Wisdom concerns understanding and judgment.

Truth concerns what is true.

Therefore the concepts can be distinguished:

γνῶσις → what is known

σοφία → wise understanding of what is known

ἀλήθεια → what is true / reality

---

10. The Conceptual Relationship

The four terms can now be arranged conceptually:

γνῶσις

Knowledge

↓

σοφία

Wisdom

↓

σοφός

The person characterized by wisdom

↓

ἀλήθεια

Truth / reality recognized through understanding

However, this diagram should not be understood as a lexical definition.

σοφός is not a stage after σοφία, and ἀλήθεια is not grammatically the “next word” after σοφία.

The diagram represents a **theological conceptual model**.

A more precise formulation is:

Knowledge provides what is known; wisdom provides discernment concerning what is known; the wise person exercises that discernment; Truth provides the reality toward which such discernment is directed.

---

11. Divine Illumination

The next step is theological.

The present study proposes the following model:

One Most High God

↓

Father, Son, Holy Spirit

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Human Spirit Illuminated

↓

Mind / Understanding Illuminated

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth Recognized

This is a theological formulation proposed by the study.

It should not be presented as though “divine illumination” were a technical lexical meaning of γνῶσις or σοφία.

Rather, the model describes how Christian theology can understand the movement from ignorance toward knowledge and wisdom.

---

12. The Spirit of Truth

The Gospel of John provides particularly important Christian language for this theological synthesis.

John 14:17 calls the Spirit:

τὸ πνεῦμα τῆς ἀληθείας

“the Spirit of Truth.”

John 16:13 similarly describes the Spirit of Truth as guiding the disciples “into all the truth.”

This creates a significant theological relationship:

Spirit of Truth → guidance into Truth

The Johannine framework therefore provides a Christian theological context in which the movement toward truth is not merely intellectual acquisition.

Truth is associated with divine revelation and the activity of the Spirit.

---

13. Divine Illumination and Human Knowing

Within the framework proposed here:

Divine illumination

does not mean that God simply deposits information into the human mind.

Rather, illumination represents the awakening or enabling of the human person to perceive, understand, discern, and recognize what is true.

The model can therefore be expressed:

Divine Illumination

↓

Human Spirit

↓

Mind Illuminated

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth Recognized

This is a theological model rather than a claim that Scripture itself presents these exact stages as a formal sequence.

---

14. The Human Person and Wisdom

The movement toward wisdom involves the whole person.

Knowledge may initially appear cognitive.

But wisdom requires more than cognition.

Wisdom involves:

- understanding
- discernment
- judgment
- orientation
- practical application

Therefore, in the theological model:

Knowledge enters the mind

but

Wisdom transforms how the person understands and responds to reality.

This provides a bridge between lexical study and spiritual transformation.

---

15. Gospel of Thomas Saying 2

The opening of Saying 2 is especially significant:

“Let the one seeking not stop seeking until he finds.”

The Greek fragment from Oxyrhynchus preserves the following progression in translation:

seeking → finding → astonishment → reigning → resting.

The Greek reconstruction is associated with:

ζητῶν — seeking

εὕρῃ — finds

θαμβηθήσεται — will be astonished

θαμβηθεὶς — having been astonished

βασιλεύσει — will reign

βασιλεύσας — having reigned

ἀναπαήσεται — will rest

The grammatical structure is especially striking because participles and finite verbs create a chain of transformation.

---

16. The Coptic Witness

The Coptic version expands the middle of the sequence.

It can be represented:

seeking

↓

finding

↓

being troubled

↓

being astonished

↓

ruling over the All

The Coptic witness therefore contains a stage of disturbance or trouble before astonishment and explicitly states that the seeker will rule “over the All.”

The difference between the Greek and Coptic witnesses is important.

The Greek fragment has the ending:

reigning → resting

The Coptic version commonly transmitted in the Nag Hammadi manuscript ends with:

ruling over the All

This textual difference must be respected rather than harmonized without explanation.

---

17. Seeking and γνῶσις

The first connection between Saying 2 and the vocabulary studied here is **seeking and knowledge**.

The seeker begins without possessing the sought-for object.

The instruction is not:

“Stop seeking because you already know.”

It is:

Continue seeking until you find.

Conceptually:

Seeking → Finding → Knowing

This provides a natural point of contact with **γνῶσις**.

The lexical meaning of γνῶσις includes knowledge and knowing, while the saying describes the process of seeking until finding.

Therefore, within the theological synthesis:

Seeking is the movement toward knowledge.

But knowledge is not the end of the process.

---

18. Finding and the Transformation of Knowledge

The most important feature of Saying 2 is that **finding does not end the process**.

The seeker finds—and then something unexpected happens.

The Greek text says that the finder will be astonished.

The Coptic version inserts trouble before astonishment.

Thus:

Finding → Trouble / Astonishment

This means that discovery is transformative.

The seeker does not simply add another piece of information to an existing collection of information.

The discovery changes the seeker's understanding.

This is where **γνῶσις** begins to move conceptually toward **σοφία**.

---

19. From γνῶσις to σοφία

Within the proposed theological model:

γνῶσις = knowledge acquired or recognized

↓

σοφία = understanding and discernment of that knowledge

The discovery of truth can therefore disturb previous assumptions.

A person may possess knowledge while still operating within an incomplete framework of understanding.

When deeper knowledge is encountered, the previous framework may need to be reorganized.

This provides a possible theological explanation for the “troubled” or “astonished” state in Saying 2.

The seeker encounters something greater than the previous understanding.

Thus:

Finding → Reassessment → Wisdom

---

20. Astonishment as Transformative Recognition

The Greek verb **θαμβέω** and its forms in the saying concern astonishment or being struck with wonder.

The sequence therefore does not present knowledge as emotionally neutral.

Finding produces astonishment.

Theologically, astonishment can be understood as the response of the human person when reality exceeds previous expectation.

The movement can be represented:

Seeking

↓

Finding

↓

Recognition

↓

Astonishment

↓

Transformation

The Coptic addition of trouble intensifies this movement:

Finding

↓

Trouble

↓

Astonishment

The important theological point is that deeper understanding can challenge the previous state of the seeker.

---

21. Wisdom as the Transformation of Knowledge

This gives a possible conceptual distinction:

γνῶσις

“I know.”

σοφία

“I understand what I know.”

ἀλήθεια

“I recognize what is true.”

These statements are not dictionary definitions.

They are a theological conceptual model derived from the lexical distinctions.

The movement can therefore be expressed:

Knowledge becomes wisdom when what is known is rightly understood.

And:

Wisdom becomes oriented toward Truth when understanding is directed toward what is actually true and real.

---

22. σοφός — The Transformed Seeker

The adjective σοφός provides another dimension.

If σοφός can describe someone who is wise, skilled, prudent, clever, or learned, then the “wise person” is not merely someone who possesses information.

The wise person has developed an ability to **understand and act**.

Therefore, within the theological synthesis:

γνῶσις

provides knowledge,

σοφία

provides wisdom,

and

σοφός

describes the person in whom such wisdom is manifested.

The seeker is therefore not merely becoming informed.

The seeker is becoming transformed.

---

23. Truth and ἀλήθεια

The next conceptual movement is toward **ἀλήθεια**.

If wisdom concerns sound understanding and discernment, its proper object is not arbitrary opinion.

Wisdom must ultimately be oriented toward what is true.

Thus:

γνῶσις → knowledge

σοφία → wisdom

ἀλήθεια → Truth

Within Christian theology, this becomes especially significant because the Johannine writings identify the Spirit as the **Spirit of Truth** and describe the Spirit as guiding believers into truth.

---

24. Truth as the Object of Wisdom

The relationship can be stated carefully:

Wisdom is not itself Truth; wisdom is the capacity to understand and judge rightly in relation to Truth.

This distinction prevents the concepts from being confused.

Therefore:

Knowledge tells us what has been apprehended.

Wisdom discerns its significance and proper application.

Truth identifies what is real and true.

Within the proposed Christian framework:

The Spirit of Truth illuminates the human person toward recognition of Truth.

---

25. Christological Dimension

Christian theology introduces another important dimension.

In the Johannine tradition, Jesus is identified with the **Word (λόγος)**, and the Spirit is identified as the **Spirit of Truth**.

Therefore, a Christian theological synthesis can place the sequence within a Christ-centered framework:

God

↓

Divine revelation

↓

Spirit of Truth

↓

Human illumination

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Recognition of Truth

↓

Christ / Living Word

This is a theological synthesis rather than a lexical claim about the Gospel of Thomas.

It seeks to interpret the transformation of the seeker through categories already important within Christian theology.

---

26. “Reign” in Saying 2

The next movement in Saying 2 is:

astonishment → reign

The Greek verb is:

βασιλεύσει

“he will reign.”

The participial form follows:

βασιλεύσας

“having reigned.”

The saying therefore connects transformation with authority.

The Coptic version makes the scope explicit:

“he will rule over the All.”

The Greek fragment, however, has the sequence leading to rest.

---

27. Reign as Spiritual Authority

Within the theological interpretation proposed here, “reign” should not automatically be understood as political domination.

A spiritual reading can understand the movement as:

Truth recognized

↓

Truth governing the person

↓

Wisdom governing action

↓

Spiritual authority

The first place of reign is therefore internal.

Truth must first become authoritative **within the person**.

Thus:

Before the seeker can meaningfully participate in spiritual reign, Truth must reign within the seeker.

This is a theological interpretation, not a lexical definition of βασιλεύω.

---

28. Truth Reigning Within

The complete theological model can now be expressed:

Divine Illumination

↓

Human Spirit Illuminated

↓

Mind Illuminated

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth Recognized

↓

Truth Reigns Within

↓

Spiritual Authority Through Christ

↓

Reign

↓

Rest

This formulation integrates the vocabulary studied with the progression of Saying 2.

---

29. “Over the All”

The Coptic expression “over the All” presents a particularly large scope.

The phrase should not automatically be converted into a political or earthly claim.

Within the theological model proposed here, “reign over the All” can be interpreted as **participation in spiritual authority**, ultimately grounded in Truth and understood through Christ.

This interpretation should remain distinguished from the textual level.

Text

The Coptic witness says that the seeker will rule over the All.

Interpretation

The statement can be understood as describing an extraordinary transformation and authority.

Theology

Within Christian synthesis, this authority may be interpreted as participation in Christ's spiritual reign.

This three-level distinction is essential for academic discipline.

---

30. Reign Through Christ

Within the Christian theological model proposed in this study:

The transformed seeker does not become an independent divine ruler.

Rather, spiritual authority is understood as derivative and participatory.

The movement is:

Truth

↓

Christ

↓

participation

↓

spiritual authority

Thus the theological statement is:

The seeker reigns through Christ rather than independently of Christ.

This preserves the Christian theological center of the interpretation.

---

31. The Meaning of Rest

The Greek witness concludes:

βασιλεύσας ἀναπαήσεται

“having reigned, he will rest.”

The Greek textual progression therefore reaches a final state of **rest**.

Rest can be interpreted theologically as:

- completion
- peace
- cessation of striving
- fulfillment
- consummation

However, the word itself should not automatically be translated as “heaven.”

Therefore:

Rest is explicit in the Greek reconstruction; heaven is a theological interpretation, not the literal lexical meaning of ἀναπαήσεται.

---

32. The Complete Spiritual Progression

The theological model can now be compared with Saying 2.

Divine Illumination Model

Illumination

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth

↓

Spiritual Authority

↓

Reign

↓

Rest

Saying 2

Seeking

↓

Finding

↓

Trouble / Astonishment

↓

Reigning

↓

Rest

The two sequences are not identical.

Rather, they intersect conceptually.

---

33. The Integrated Model

A fuller synthesis can therefore be proposed:

Seeking

↓

Finding

↓

γνῶσις — Knowledge

↓

Trouble / Astonishment

↓

σοφία — Wisdom

↓

σοφός — Wise / transformed person

↓

ἀλήθεια — Truth recognized

↓

Truth reigns within

↓

Spiritual authority through Christ

↓

Reign

↓

Rest

This is the central theological model of this study.

Again, it is important to emphasize:

This diagram is a theological synthesis constructed by the study. It is not a claim that the Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 itself contains these four Greek lexical terms.

---

34. Why Finding Produces Astonishment

One of the deepest features of Saying 2 is the relationship between discovery and astonishment.

Ordinary information often produces confirmation.

Deep discovery can produce transformation.

The difference can be expressed:

Information adds something to the mind.

Wisdom changes how the mind understands.

Truth can transform the person's understanding of reality.

Therefore, the saying's astonishment can be interpreted within the proposed model as the psychological and spiritual response to transformative recognition.

The seeker does not merely say:

“I have learned something new.”

Rather:

“What I have discovered changes how I understand reality.”

---

35. Knowledge, Wisdom, and Transformation

The theological sequence can therefore be summarized:

Stage 1 — Seeking

The person recognizes that something is not yet known.

Stage 2 — Finding

The seeker encounters or recognizes something previously sought.

Stage 3 — Knowledge

The person now possesses or recognizes knowledge.

Stage 4 — Trouble / Astonishment

The new discovery challenges previous understanding.

Stage 5 — Wisdom

The person integrates knowledge into deeper understanding and discernment.

Stage 6 — Truth

The person recognizes what is true and real.

Stage 7 — Reign

Truth becomes authoritative within the person and produces spiritual authority.

Stage 8 — Rest

The process reaches completion and peace.

---

36. The Role of the Spirit of Truth

The Johannine concept of the **Spirit of Truth** provides an important Christian theological parallel.

John 14:17 identifies the Spirit as:

τὸ πνεῦμα τῆς ἀληθείας

and John 16:13 describes the Spirit as guiding believers into truth.

Within the model proposed here:

Spirit of Truth

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Human understanding

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth recognized

The Spirit therefore functions not merely as a source of information but as the divine agent of guidance into Truth.

---

37. The Relationship Between σοφία and Divine Wisdom

A further distinction is necessary.

Greek σοφία can refer to ordinary human skill or wisdom as well as philosophical wisdom. Therefore, one should not automatically assume that every occurrence of σοφία means divine wisdom.

Context is decisive.

In Christian theology, however, σοφία can acquire a specifically theological significance when it is associated with God's wisdom.

The lexical range makes such theological usage possible, but theology determines the particular sense in a given passage.

Therefore:

Lexicon establishes semantic possibility; context establishes meaning; theology establishes theological significance.

---

38. The Wise Person and Truth

The concept of σοφός can now be placed into the larger model.

A σοφός person is not simply one who possesses information.

The person is characterized by wisdom, skill, intelligence, prudence, or understanding according to context.

Within this theological framework, the truly transformed wise person is one whose knowledge has become:

understood

discerned

ordered toward Truth

expressed in action

Thus:

γνῶσις without σοφία

may remain incomplete.

σοφία without ἀλήθεια

may become merely human judgment.

But:

γνῶσις + σοφία oriented toward ἀλήθεια

provides the conceptual foundation for the theological model proposed here.

---

39. Important Lexical Caution

The study must avoid making an artificial equation:

γνῶσις = σοφία = ἀλήθεια

These words do not mean the same thing.

A better formulation is:

γνῶσις — knowledge

σοφία — wisdom

σοφός — wise/skilled person

ἀλήθεια — truth/reality

Their relationship is conceptual rather than synonymous.

Likewise, it would be linguistically unsound to claim:

“σοφός literally means Truth.”

It does not.

Nor does:

“σοφία literally means knowledge.”

It does not.

Nor does:

“γνῶσις literally means wisdom.”

It does not.

The strength of the theological model lies not in redefining the words but in relating their established meanings.

---

40. The Principle of Progressive Understanding

The entire model can therefore be understood as a movement of progressive understanding:

Not knowing

↓

Seeking

↓

Finding

↓

Knowing

↓

Understanding

↓

Wisdom

↓

Discernment

↓

Truth

↓

Transformation

This corresponds conceptually to the transformative structure of Saying 2.

The seeker is not told simply to obtain an answer.

The seeker is told to **continue seeking until finding**.

The discovery then becomes transformative.

---

41. Parabolic and Wisdom-Saying Hermeneutic

Saying 2 is a short wisdom saying.

Its language is compressed:

seek

find

be astonished

reign

rest

Because the statement is compressed, its meaning cannot be exhausted merely by translating individual words.

A responsible interpretation should therefore consider:

1. lexical meaning,
2. grammar,
3. literary structure,
4. surrounding Thomas sayings,
5. historical context,
6. parallels in early Christianity,
7. broader Christian theology.

The saying may therefore be read at both a surface and deeper symbolic level, provided that the deeper interpretation is clearly identified as interpretation rather than presented as lexical fact.

---

42. Saying 2 as a Transformation of the Seeker

The deepest theological significance of the saying, within this model, is that **the seeker himself is transformed**.

The process is not:

question → answer → stop

It is:

seeking → finding → disturbance → astonishment → transformation → authority → rest

This is why the finding does not terminate the journey.

Finding begins a deeper transformation.

---

43. Knowledge as the Beginning, Not the End

This study therefore proposes:

Knowledge is the beginning of transformation, not its final goal.

γνῶσις provides the knowledge that has been discovered.

σοφία provides deeper understanding and discernment.

σοφός describes the person who embodies such wisdom.

ἀλήθεια provides the reality toward which the understanding is directed.

Within Christian theology, the Spirit of Truth guides the believer toward Truth.

Thus:

Knowledge informs.

Wisdom transforms understanding.

Truth establishes reality.

---

44. Theological Synthesis

The proposed Christian theological synthesis can now be stated in one continuous movement:

The Most High God illuminates the human person through divine revelation and the work of the Spirit of Truth. The illuminated person seeks, receives knowledge, and develops understanding. Knowledge, when integrated through wisdom, produces discernment. Wisdom enables the person to recognize Truth. Truth then becomes authoritative within the person. Through Christ, this inward transformation is understood as participation in spiritual authority. The movement culminates not merely in authority but in rest.

This is the theological interpretation proposed by this study.

---

45. Central Thesis

The central thesis may therefore be formulated as follows:

Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 can be read, within a Christian theological framework, as a compressed account of transformative seeking in which finding does not terminate the seeker's journey but initiates a deeper transformation. The Greek concepts γνῶσις, σοφία, σοφός, and ἀλήθεια provide a useful theological vocabulary for distinguishing knowledge, wisdom, the wise person, and Truth. Divine illumination may be understood as the enabling of this movement: the human person receives knowledge, develops wisdom, recognizes Truth, and becomes transformed by that Truth. The saying's movement from astonishment to reign and finally to rest can then be interpreted as the culmination of this transformation, with spiritual authority understood as participation through Christ rather than independent domination.

---

46. Conclusion

The Greek vocabulary examined in this study demonstrates that **knowledge, wisdom, and Truth are related but distinct concepts**.

γνῶσις concerns knowledge and knowing.

σοφία encompasses skill, intelligence, practical wisdom, learning, and broader wisdom.

σοφός describes the person characterized by such qualities—wise, skilled, clever, learned, or prudent according to context.

ἀλήθεια concerns truth, reality, and what is true rather than false or merely apparent.

These distinctions allow a more precise theological model to emerge.

The progression can be represented:

γνῶσις

Knowledge

↓

σοφία

Wisdom

↓

σοφός

Wise person

↓

ἀλήθεια

Truth recognized

↓

Truth reigning within

↓

Spiritual authority through Christ

↓

Reign

↓

Rest

When placed beside Gospel of Thomas Saying 2, this model illuminates a significant feature of the saying: **finding is not the end**.

The seeker finds, becomes astonished, and then enters a new state of existence. The Greek witness presents the movement toward reigning and resting; the Coptic witness adds trouble and “ruling over the All.”

Theologically, this can be understood as a transformation from **seeking to knowing, from knowing to wisdom, from wisdom to recognition of Truth, and from recognition of Truth to a transformed mode of spiritual existence**.

The ultimate movement is therefore not merely:

“I know.”

It is:

“I know → I understand → I discern → I recognize Truth → Truth reigns within me.”

Within the Christian framework proposed by this study, this transformation is associated with divine illumination and the activity of the **Spirit of Truth**, who in Johannine theology guides believers into Truth.

The final stage of the Greek saying is **rest**.

Thus the complete theological movement may be expressed:

Seeking → Finding → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth → Transformation → Reign → Rest

This sequence should remain explicitly identified as a **theological synthesis**, not as a claim that every stage is directly stated by the lexical meanings of the Greek words or by Saying 2 itself.

Bibliography and Primary Lexical Sources

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4. **Oxyrhynchus Papyri, P.Oxy. 654.** Greek fragments of the Gospel of Thomas, including Saying 2.

5. **Nag Hammadi Codex II, 2.** Coptic Gospel of Thomas, Saying 2.

6. **Gospel of John 14:17; 16:13.** Johannine terminology concerning the **Spirit of Truth** and guidance into Truth.

Final Conceptual Diagram

ONE MOST HIGH GOD

↓

DIVINE ILLUMINATION

↓

HUMAN SPIRIT ILLUMINATED

↓

MIND / UNDERSTANDING ILLUMINATED

↓

γνῶσις — KNOWLEDGE

↓

σοφία — WISDOM

↓

σοφός — THE WISE / TRANSFORMED PERSON

↓

ἀλήθεια — TRUTH RECOGNIZED

↓

TRUTH REIGNS WITHIN

↓

SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY THROUGH CHRIST

↓

REIGN

↓

REST

Central principle:

Knowledge is acquired; wisdom is developed; Truth is recognized; and the transformed person lives under the reign of Truth.

[Blog Version]

Greek Word Study: “Wise” — σοφός

Introduction

The Greek word commonly translated **“wise”** is:

σοφός

Transliteration

sophos

Part of speech

Adjective

Basic meaning

wise, skilled, clever, learned, discerning

The noun **σοφία** means “wisdom,” while **σοφός** describes a person or thing as “wise” or “skilled.” The relationship can therefore be expressed:

σοφία = wisdom
σοφός = wise

The distinction is important for the theological model developed in this research.

A person can possess **σοφία (wisdom)** and therefore be described as **σοφός (wise)**.

---

1. The Basic Meaning of σοφός

The Greek adjective **σοφός** has a broad semantic range.

Classical Greek lexicography gives meanings including:

- skilled;
- clever;
- wise;
- prudent;
- learned;
- knowledgeable;
- intellectually capable.

LSJ begins its definition with the senses **“skilled, clever, wise.”** It can describe someone skilled in an art or craft and can also describe someone wise in practical or intellectual matters.

Therefore, **σοφός does not originally mean only “religiously wise.”**

Its meaning depends upon context.

A person can be:

- skilled in an occupation;
- clever in reasoning;
- learned in education;
- prudent in practical matters;
- or wise in a deeper philosophical or theological sense.

---

2. σοφός and σοφία

The relationship between the adjective and noun is fundamental.

σοφός

wise

σοφία

wisdom

Thus:

σοφός describes the person.

σοφία describes the quality or state of wisdom.

For example, the theological movement can be expressed:

σοφία → σοφός

wisdom → wise

A person who possesses wisdom can be described as wise.

---

3. Wisdom Is More Than Information

The distinction between **knowledge** and **wisdom** becomes important here.

A person can possess:

γνῶσις — knowledge

without necessarily being:

σοφός — wise.

Knowledge concerns what a person knows.

Wisdom concerns the person's ability to understand and properly apply what is known.

Therefore, within the theological framework of this study:

Knowledge can inform the person; wisdom makes the person wise.

The movement can be represented:

γνῶσις → σοφία → σοφός

Knowledge → Wisdom → Wise person

This is a theological conceptual sequence, not a claim that the three Greek words are grammatically dependent upon one another.

---

4. σοφός as Skilled

One of the earliest and broadest meanings of **σοφός** is **skilled**.

LSJ gives examples where σοφός describes people skilled in particular crafts or arts.

This is significant because the original concept of wisdom was not necessarily limited to abstract intellectual knowledge.

A person could be “wise” because that person possessed excellence or skill in a particular activity.

Therefore:

σοφός can describe someone who knows how to do something well.

This provides an important background to the later philosophical and theological meanings of the word.

---

5. σοφός as Learned

The word can also describe someone who is **learned or educated**.

New Testament lexicons identify uses of σοφός for learned or intellectually cultivated people.

Thus:

σοφός

can move semantically from:

skill

to:

learning

to:

wisdom

depending upon context.

---

6. σοφός as Practically Wise

The word can also describe someone who possesses **practical wisdom**.

A practically wise person knows how to act appropriately in a particular situation.

This is more than possessing theoretical information.

It involves:

understanding → judgment → appropriate action

New Testament lexical sources identify this practical dimension particularly in passages such as Ephesians 5:15 and James 3:13.

Therefore:

σοφός can describe a person whose understanding is demonstrated through wise conduct.

---

7. σοφός and Spiritual Wisdom

In Christian texts, σοφός can acquire a specifically spiritual dimension.

The New Testament uses the word for people characterized by wisdom and also uses it of God.

For example, Romans 16:27 contains the expression:

μόνῳ σοφῷ θεῷ

meaning:

“to the only wise God.”

Here σοφός is applied directly to God.

This is particularly significant for the theological model of this study.

The Greek text does not merely say that God possesses information.

God is described as **wise**.

Thus:

God is σοφός — wise.

---

8. God as the Wise One

The application of σοφός to God establishes an important theological distinction.

Human wisdom is derivative.

Divine wisdom is foundational.

The Christian theological model can therefore be represented:

God — the Wise One

↓

Divine Wisdom

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Human Understanding

↓

Human Wisdom

The human person does not become wise independently of God.

Within this theological framework, human wisdom ultimately depends upon divine illumination.

---

9. The Wise Person

If **σοφός** describes the wise person, then the theological question becomes:

What makes a person truly wise?

Within the framework proposed here, true wisdom is not merely the possession of large amounts of information.

A wise person is one whose knowledge has been illuminated, understood, integrated, and rightly directed toward Truth.

Therefore:

The wise person is not simply the person who knows the most, but the person whose knowledge has become understanding and whose understanding is ordered toward Truth.

---

10. Knowledge and the Wise Person

The relationship can be represented:

γνῶσις

↓

Knowledge

↓

σοφία

↓

Wisdom

↓

σοφός

↓

Wise Person

The progression is not a lexical definition, but it provides a useful theological model.

The person first receives knowledge.

Knowledge develops into wisdom.

Wisdom becomes evident in the person.

The person can therefore be described as **σοφός**.

---

11. The Wise Heart

The theological model developed in this research emphasizes that wisdom should not remain merely intellectual.

The wise person possesses an illuminated inner life.

Thus:

Divine Illumination

↓

Spirit

↓

Mind

↓

Heart

↓

Wisdom

↓

Wise Person

The heart is important because wisdom ultimately affects how a person lives.

A person may know something intellectually while failing to live according to that knowledge.

Biblical wisdom therefore has a practical and moral dimension.

---

12. Wise and Truth

The relationship between **σοφός** and **ἀλήθεια** is also important.

The word σοφός itself does not mean “truth.”

Likewise:

ἀλήθεια ≠ σοφός

But a theological relationship can be established:

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth

↓

Wise Person

Within this model, the wise person is one who has learned to understand reality according to Truth.

Therefore:

Wisdom does not replace Truth; wisdom enables the person to recognize and respond appropriately to Truth.

---

13. Wise and the Spirit of Truth

The theological model can then be extended to the concept of the **Spirit of Truth**.

The movement becomes:

Spirit of Truth

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Wise Person

The Spirit illuminates the human spirit.

The person receives knowledge.

Knowledge develops into wisdom.

The person becomes wise.

Thus the word **σοφός** describes the transformed person rather than the divine source of illumination itself.

---

14. Jesus and Wisdom

Within Christian theology, Jesus Christ is associated with divine wisdom.

The New Testament can describe Christ in relation to God's wisdom, particularly in 1 Corinthians 1:24 and 1 Corinthians 1:30.

This creates an important theological relationship:

God's Wisdom

↓

Christ

↓

Human Illumination

↓

Human Wisdom

The study therefore understands Jesus Christ not merely as someone who teaches wisdom but, within Christian theology, as centrally related to God's wisdom and revelation.

15. The Wise Seeker

This becomes particularly relevant to the theme of seeking.

The seeker begins without complete understanding.

The seeker seeks.

The seeker receives illumination.

The seeker gains knowledge.

Knowledge develops into wisdom.

Wisdom enables recognition of Truth.

Therefore:

The seeker becomes wise through the transformation of knowledge into understanding under divine illumination.

The theological sequence is:

Seeking

↓

Illumination

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Wise Person

↓

Truth

---

16. Connection with Gospel of Thomas Saying 2

This word study can be placed alongside Saying 2, although the word **σοφός** itself should not be inserted into the saying unless the manuscript actually contains it.

The saying describes:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The theological model proposed here explains the seeker's transformation as:

Seeking → Illumination → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth → Transformation

Thus the two sequences can be brought into dialogue:

Saying 2

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

Theological Model

Illumination → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth → Transformation

The connection is interpretive, not lexical.

---

17. The Wise Person and Astonishment

An important point emerges from this relationship.

Wisdom does not necessarily eliminate astonishment.

Indeed, deeper understanding may produce greater astonishment because the person realizes how much greater divine reality is than previously understood.

Thus:

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Recognition of Truth

↓

Astonishment

The wise person is therefore not necessarily the person who believes that everything has become simple.

The wise person recognizes the depth of what has been revealed.

---

18. The Wise Person and Reign

The theological interpretation can then connect wisdom with the language of reigning.

A person who has been illuminated and transformed by Truth does not “reign” through personal pride.

Rather, the proposed interpretation understands spiritual authority as flowing from Truth.

The movement becomes:

Divine Illumination

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth

↓

Inner Transformation

↓

Spiritual Authority

↓

Reign

Thus:

True spiritual authority comes after transformation, not before it.

---

19. The Wise Person and the Heart

The final destination of wisdom is therefore not simply the intellect.

Wisdom must reach the heart.

The complete movement becomes:

Spirit Illuminated

↓

Mind Enlightened

↓

Knowledge Received

↓

Wisdom Developed

↓

Heart Awakened

↓

Truth Recognized

↓

Life Transformed

This is the theological meaning of becoming **σοφός** within the framework of this study.

---

20. Lexical Distinction

For scholarly accuracy, the following distinctions should be maintained:

σοφός

wise, skilled, clever, learned

σοφία

wisdom

γνῶσις

knowledge

ἀλήθεια

truth, reality

These words are related but are not interchangeable.

Therefore:

σοφός does not mean “Truth.”

σοφός does not mean “knowledge.”

σοφός means “wise” or, depending on context, “skilled, learned, clever.”

The theological meaning arises from how wisdom relates to knowledge and Truth within the larger Christian framework.

---

21. Proposed Theological Model

The study can therefore formulate the following model:

One Most High God

↓

Divine Wisdom

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Spirit of Truth

↓

Human Spirit

↓

Knowledge — γνῶσις

↓

Wisdom — σοφία

↓

Wise Person — σοφός

↓

Truth — ἀλήθεια

↓

Jesus Christ, the Living Word

↓

Truth Reigns Within

↓

Spiritual Authority

↓

Reign

↓

Rest

Again, this is a **theological synthesis**, not a claim that these Greek terms occur together in this exact sequence in the ancient texts.

---

22. Conclusion

The Greek adjective **σοφός** provides an important dimension to the study of wisdom.

It does not simply mean “a person who knows many things.”

Its semantic range includes being:

- skilled;
- clever;
- learned;
- prudent;
- wise;
- and, in theological contexts, wise in relation to God.

The noun **σοφία** describes wisdom, while **σοφός** describes the person or entity characterized by wisdom.

The theological relationship can therefore be expressed:

γνῶσις → σοφία → σοφός

Knowledge → Wisdom → Wise Person

When divine Truth is added:

Knowledge → Wisdom → Wise Person → Recognition of Truth

And when divine illumination is placed at the beginning:

Divine Illumination → Knowledge → Wisdom → Wise Person → Truth

Within the Christian theological framework of this study, the ultimate source of illumination is the one Most High God, the Spirit of Truth illuminates the human spirit, and Jesus Christ, the Living Word, stands at the center of the Christian understanding of divine Truth.

The central proposition can therefore be stated:

A wise person is not merely one who possesses knowledge; a wise person is one whose knowledge has been illuminated, deepened into wisdom, and directed toward recognition of Truth.

Thus, in the theological model proposed here:

The illuminated spirit receives knowledge.

Knowledge develops into wisdom.

Wisdom makes the person wise.

The wise person recognizes Truth.

Truth transforms the whole person.

Note on “Clever” in the Greek Word σοφός

The Greek word **σοφός (*sophos*)** is commonly translated as **“wise,”** but its semantic range is broader. Greek lexicons include meanings such as **skilled, clever, learned, prudent, and wise**.

The word therefore should not automatically be restricted to the modern meaning of “wise.”

1. Cleverness as Ability

One important dimension of **σοφός** is the idea of **ability or skill**.

A person may be described as σοφός because that person knows how to perform something skillfully.

In this sense:

σοφός = one who possesses demonstrated ability.

The word can therefore describe someone who is skilled in an art, craft, intellectual activity, or practical task.

The meaning is not simply that the person has information.

The person knows **how to use what has been learned**.

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2. Cleverness as Practical Intelligence

The word can also describe someone who is **clever or capable in practical matters**.

This is an important distinction.

Knowledge may answer:

“What do I know?”

Cleverness can answer:

“How can I use what I know?”

Wisdom goes further:

“How should what I know be understood and used rightly?”

Thus the concepts can be distinguished:

Knowledge → Understanding → Clever application → Wisdom

The precise relationship varies according to context, but this provides a useful conceptual framework.

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3. Clever Does Not Mean Cunning

Modern English can give the word **“clever”** a negative sense, such as being crafty, manipulative, or cunning.

That should not automatically be read into **σοφός**.

The Greek word can describe intellectual ability, skill, prudence, or wisdom without implying dishonesty.

Therefore:

σοφός should not automatically be interpreted as “cunning.”

The surrounding context determines whether the emphasis is on skill, intelligence, prudence, learning, or wisdom.

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4. From Knowledge to Cleverness

Within the theological framework of this study, the relationship may be represented as:

γνῶσις — Knowledge

↓

Understanding

↓

σοφός — Skilled / Clever

↓

σοφία — Wisdom

Knowledge gives the person something to understand.

Cleverness or skill demonstrates the person's ability to work with that understanding.

Wisdom gives that understanding deeper discernment and proper direction.

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5. Cleverness and Divine Illumination

When this concept is incorporated into the theological model of divine illumination, the movement can be expressed:

Divine Illumination

↓

Human Spirit Illuminated

↓

Knowledge

↓

Understanding

↓

Skillful Application

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth

The purpose of divine illumination is therefore not merely to make a person intellectually informed.

The illumination produces an increasingly transformed person whose knowledge can be understood and applied wisely.

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6. Cleverness and the Wise Person

Because **σοφός** can mean both “clever” and “wise,” the word can describe the person in whom understanding has become demonstrated ability.

Thus:

A σοφός person is not merely someone who knows; the person has the ability to understand and act skillfully.

This provides a bridge between **knowledge** and **wisdom**.

The person moves from:

Knowing

to

Understanding

to

Skillful action

to

Wisdom

---

7. Theological Caution

For academic purposes, it is important not to claim that **σοφός = clever = wise** in every context.

The semantic range includes these ideas, but the context determines which sense is most appropriate.

Therefore, the safest formulation is:

The Greek adjective σοφός has a semantic range that includes skill, cleverness, learning, prudence, and wisdom. In a theological context, its precise force must be determined by the surrounding text.

This preserves the richness of the Greek word without forcing one English translation into every occurrence.

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8. Summary

The concept can be summarized as:

σοφός

Wise — Skilled — Clever — Learned — Prudent

The important theological distinction is:

Cleverness is an expression of ability; wisdom is deeper discernment; Truth provides the reality toward which wisdom is directed.

Thus, within the divine-illumination model:

Illumination → Knowledge → Understanding → Skill → Wisdom → Truth

The **σοφός** person is therefore not simply a person who possesses information. The person has developed the ability to understand and apply knowledge, and in its higher theological sense, to live according to wisdom and Truth.